

Frequently Asked Questions – Corporate Strategy

General Guidelines:

In your interviews, try to apply firm-specific answers whenever applicable. It is important to convey that you have not only researched the company and understand the company's culture but also that you are interested in the company and the role is aligned with your goals and aspirations.

Be prepared for consulting style cases (or mini-cases) in your interview. It is critical that you have researched the company's industry and related opportunities/challenges as cases will likely center on these areas. However, you may also receive unrelated industry case scenarios. A typical Corporate Strategy interview often consists of half "fit" and half "case" interview. In some cases, the fit interview will account for a larger share of overall interview time. However, even if these are typical examples, do not be surprised if you have interviews with all case questions or no case questions. Talking to second-year students is the best way to learn what to expect for each interview.

For your final round interviews, you will typically be asked to fly to the company's location for an "intern fly-in" interview, along with other peers from Booth and students from other business schools. It will often take place on a Friday, and may consist of anywhere between 3-5 different interviews. It is also likely to be preceded by a cocktail/ evening get-together (i.e. Thursday evening) and/or one on a Friday evening. These meet-ups serve as an excellent platform not only for you to meet and have a chance to interact with employees/ managers of the firm from different departments, but also can give those managers a chance to see/ interact with potential candidates prior to interviews. These meet-ups should be treated as an "unofficial" interview session and one should be prepared accordingly.

Fit with Strategic Planning Role

- Please walk me through your resume/tell me about yourself.
- Why do you want a position in corporate strategy/ strategic planning?
- What are your thoughts on the evolution of this industry vertical over the next few years (it could be in terms of products, technologies, markets, etc.)?
- Name a few trends you see in the industry currently.
- What do you consider to be the competitive landscape of our industry, specifically highlighting our company's strengths and weaknesses relative to our peers?
- Where do you see this industry going / How do you think the [] industry is different from the rest of the [] industry?
- What do you perceive are the negatives about this company? How would you change/improve them?
- What are the main challenges the company faces within the industry's competitive landscape? How can the company deal with these challenges?
- What has been your most significant leadership experience?

- Describe a situation when you had to work with ambiguity. How did you deal with the situation and what was the result?
- Tell me about a situation at work where you experienced conflict and how you resolved it.
- Describe an experience when you had to convince someone/a peer/a manager.
- What questions do you have about our company? / Do you have any additional questions about our company?
- What are your short-term and long-term goals?
- Why did you attend business school?
- How do you believe your experiences qualify you for a strategic planning role in our company?
- Why do you think you are the best person for this job?
- Why did you decide to leave your previous career?
- What are you looking for in a strategic planning internship (or full-time position)?
- Are you also considering corporate development?

Fit with the Firm

- Which, if any other industries/functions are you considering and why?
- Why does this company interest you or why do you want to join this company?
- What do you see as your long-term path with this company?
- How have you researched this opportunity/learned about our company?
- What other companies are you interviewing with?
- How will you decide between competing offers?
- What do you think will be the toughest part of this job?
- Are you also considering consulting? Is strategic planning your backup plan?
- What do you like most about this company?
- Why do you want to live in [insert location] city?
- What do you think is the most important characteristic of someone on our team?
 - Please give an example of a time when you have exhibited that characteristic.
- What do you think the culture here is like?

Leadership Skills

- Describe your leadership style.
- How do you define leadership?
- What is the one thing I should take back to my fellow interviewers to remember you by?
- What was the most challenging or riskiest decision you have made? What was the outcome?
- How do you set targets? How do you quantify and measure the outcomes?
- Which leader is your role model and why? How has he/she influenced you?
- In hindsight, is there any decision that you regret taking? Explain the rationale behind making that decision.
- If you could go back in time and change/alter one decision that you made, what would it be and why?
{Hint: avoid the cliché “I wouldn’t change anything or every decision that I took was successful/ fruitful.”}
- Tell me about a time when you failed.
- Tell me about an ethical or moral dilemma you have faced.

Analytical Skills

- Tell me about a time when you had to use data to convince someone.
- What courses do you enjoy most at Chicago Booth? Why?
- What problems did you resolve in your most recent job?
- Tell me about a time you’ve done financial analysis.
- How do the three major financial statements connect to each other?

Team Skills

- Tell me the advantages and disadvantages of teamwork.
- Tell me about your last experience working in a team and the role you played.
- Tell me about a time when your opinion was challenged. How did you handle it?
- Tell me about a challenging interpersonal experience and how you resolved it.
- Give me an example of when you were a mentor to someone else.
- Describe a situation when you needed to influence someone without having the authority to command him/her.
- Describe a time where you resolved a disagreement.
- Provide an example of how you have successfully used a network within an organization.
- How would other members of your teams in business school / last job describe you?
- Describe a team experience that did not work well. Why didn’t it work well? How did you handle it? If you were to do it all over again, how would you do it differently?
- Describe a team experience that worked well. Why do you think did it work well?

Additional Questions about your Fit with the Firm/Role

- Describe your presentation skills and experiences.
- Tell me something that you are passionate about.
- Now that you have been in business school for some time, what piece of advice, that you did not know before, would you give your old company?
- On your last performance evaluation, what was something you needed to work on?
- What do you like to do for fun?
- What motivates you?
- What was the most interesting class you took in undergrad (or Booth thus far) and why?
- Why did you want to leave [your job before Booth]?
- How did you prepare for this interview?
- Where do you see yourself in 10 years?

Examples of Case-style Questions

- Our company is considering a joint venture/M&A transaction/strategic partnership with an overseas company. What should we consider? Why?
- One of our business units is experiencing a decline in profitability. What would you look at to resolve this problem?
- We are launching a new product. How should we go about sizing the market? How should we brand this product? What distribution strategy should we consider? What other groups within our company would you work with? Can you calculate incremental revenue and profit (given cannibalization)?
- We are entering a new market where local competition is intense. We can lower our prices only by lowering our product quality. Should we do it? What should we consider?
- You're an intern and you are asked to figure out an area in our company to divest. What would you do?
- You're a product manager meeting with a colleague who is a product manager for a similar but different product. You are meeting to plan for a presentation to both of your bosses. You each have three new features you want to push, but you only get 3 in total. What do you do?
- How many Barbie dolls are in the homes of children 10 and under in the United States?
- Should we invest in [X asset]? What information would you ask for? How would you value this asset?
- What is a well-marketed product that isn't a great product?

***Note:** Case-style questions can vary dramatically. Consult materials from CMSG and MCG for examples, and talk to second-years about what they were asked. Think about topics from Competitive Strategy and Marketing (for CPG firms). No matter the type of case question you receive, take notes, ask clarifying questions, organize your thoughts before responding, and explain why you're making a particular recommendation.*